FOR PHYSICAL THERAPY PRACTICES

5 FRONT DESK SCRIPTS
THAT STOP REVENUE FROM WALKING OUT YOUR DOOR

Word-for-word scripts your front desk team can start using today to book more patients, reduce no-shows, and close revenue gaps.

Survival STRATEGIES INC.

TRAINING AND CONSULTING FOR PRIVATE PRACTICES

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THE PROBLEM YOU CAN'T SEE

Your front desk is the financial gateway of your practice. Every call, every check-in, every scheduling conversation either brings revenue in or lets it walk out the door.

The numbers are hard to ignore:

What's Happening	The Cost
Practices miss 34-42% of incoming calls during business hours	$200 lost per missed call
35% of callers put on hold hang up within 45 seconds	Patient goes to a competitor
Only 1 in 9 phone leads converts to an appointment	89% of leads wasted
85% of callers who can't get through never call back	Permanent patient loss
41% of callers who can't get through call a competitor instead	Revenue goes to the practice down the road

The fix is not more marketing or more phone lines. It is giving your front desk team the exact words to say in the five situations where revenue is most commonly lost. That is what these scripts do.

Print them. Put them at every desk. Practice them out loud. The difference shows up in your schedule and your bank account within weeks.

HOW TO USE THESE SCRIPTS

- Print a copy for every front desk team member.
- Read each script out loud with your team. Practice it. Role-play it.
- Keep the scripts at the front desk for reference during real calls.
- Adapt the language to match your practice's personality, but keep the structure.
- Review weekly for the first month, then monthly after that.

SCRIPT 1

How to Answer the Phone and Convert a New Patient Inquiry

Use when: A potential new patient calls asking about your PT services.

THE GOAL

Get their name, understand their need, build confidence, and book the evaluation. Do not let this call end with "I'll think about it."

THE SCRIPT

FRONT DESK: Thank you for calling [Practice Name], this is [Your Name]. How can I help you today?

CALLER: *Hi, I'm looking for physical therapy. I hurt my [back/knee/shoulder]...*

FRONT DESK: I'm sorry to hear that. You've called the right place. Can I get your name?

CALLER: *[Gives name]*

FRONT DESK: Thank you, [Patient Name]. So I can help you best, can you tell me a little more about what's going on? When did it start, and how is it affecting your day-to-day?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Let them talk. Listen. Do not rush to schedule. People book with people who listen.*

CALLER: *[Describes their issue]*

FRONT DESK: That sounds really frustrating. The good news is that's exactly what we work with every day, and our therapists get great results with [their condition]. What we'd want to do is get you in for an evaluation so the therapist can take a look, figure out exactly what's going on, and put a plan together for you. Does that sound good?

CALLER: *Yeah, that sounds good. How much does it cost?*

FRONT DESK: Great question. It depends on your insurance plan, so let me help you with that. Do you have your insurance card handy? I can check your benefits right now so you know exactly what to expect before you come in.

⚠️ **NOTE:** *If they don't have the card: "No problem at all. Can I get your name, date of birth, and the best number to reach you? I'll verify your benefits and call you right back with the details and get you scheduled."*

CALLER: *[Provides insurance info or contact details]*

FRONT DESK: Perfect. I'm going to [check your benefits now / verify and call you right back]. In the meantime, let me get you on the schedule. We have openings on [Day] at [Time] or [Day] at [Time]. Which works better for you?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Always offer two specific times. Never say "When would you like to come in?" Open-ended questions let people delay. Specific options create action.*

CALLER: *[Picks a time]*

FRONT DESK: [Patient Name], you're all set for [Day] at [Time] with [Therapist Name]. We'll send you a confirmation and some quick paperwork to fill out ahead of time so your visit goes smoothly. Is there anything else I can help you with?

FRONT DESK: We look forward to seeing you. Have a great day!

WHY THIS SCRIPT WORKS

This script does three things most front desk calls miss: it listens before selling, it addresses cost concerns without losing the patient, and it locks in the appointment before ending the call. The two-option scheduling technique alone can double conversion rates on phone inquiries.

SCRIPT 2

How to Explain Insurance Benefits and Patient Responsibility

Use when: A patient asks about their coverage, copay, or what they'll owe.

THE GOAL

Clearly communicate what insurance covers and what the patient is responsible for, without confusing them, scaring them off, or making promises you can't keep.

THE SCRIPT

FRONT DESK: [Patient Name], I've checked your benefits and want to walk you through what I found so there are no surprises.

FRONT DESK: Your plan covers physical therapy visits. Here's how it works: you have a [copay amount] copay per visit, which is due at the time of your appointment. [If applicable: You also have a [deductible amount] deductible, which means you'll pay the full visit rate until that amount is met for the year, and then your copay kicks in.]

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Pause here. Let them process. Don't rush into the next detail.*

CALLER: *OK, so how many visits do I get?*

FRONT DESK: Your plan allows [X visits / has a therapy cap of $X] per year. We'll keep track of that for you as we go so you always know where you stand. If we ever get close to that limit, we'll let you know ahead of time and talk through your options.

CALLER: *What happens if I hit the limit?*

FRONT DESK: Great question. If we get to that point, we have a couple of options. Sometimes we can request additional visits from your insurance company if the therapist documents that more treatment is needed. We can also discuss a self-pay rate that's very manageable. But honestly, most of our patients see significant improvement well before they reach their limit.

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Do not guarantee coverage or visit counts. Always use language like "based on what I'm seeing in your benefits" and "we'll keep you informed as we go."*

CALLER: *OK, that makes sense.*

FRONT DESK: I just want you to focus on getting better. We handle the insurance side, and we'll always keep you in the loop on where things stand. Sound good?

WHY THIS SCRIPT WORKS

The biggest reason patients hesitate or drop off is financial uncertainty. This script eliminates the unknown. It is honest, clear, and reassuring without making promises. The line "we'll keep track of that for you" takes the burden off the patient and positions your practice as an ally, not a billing department.

SCRIPT 3

How to Confirm Appointments and Reduce No-Shows

Use when: Making confirmation calls or responding to cancellation attempts.

THE GOAL

Go beyond a reminder. Reinforce the value of the visit so the patient prioritises showing up. When they try to cancel, save the appointment.

PART A: THE CONFIRMATION CALL (48 Hours Before)

FRONT DESK: Hi [Patient Name], this is [Your Name] from [Practice Name]. I'm calling to confirm your appointment on [Day] at [Time] with [Therapist Name].

FRONT DESK: [Therapist Name] has reviewed your chart and is looking forward to working with you on [their specific issue, e.g. "getting that shoulder moving better" or "building on the progress from last visit"].

> ⚠️ **NOTE:** *Personalising the confirmation with their specific issue makes it about their health, not just a calendar slot. It makes them feel expected and valued.*

FRONT DESK: You're all set. We'll see you [Day] at [Time]. Do you have any questions before your visit?

PART B: WHEN A PATIENT TRIES TO CANCEL

CALLER: *I need to cancel my appointment on Thursday.*

FRONT DESK: I understand things come up. Before I take you off the schedule, can I ask what's going on? I want to make sure we keep your progress on track.

> ⚠️ **NOTE:** *This is the key line. Do not just say "OK, we'll cancel that for you." Always ask why and offer an alternative.*

CALLER: *[Gives reason]*

If it's a scheduling conflict:

FRONT DESK: Totally understand. Let's find another time this week so we don't lose momentum. I have [Time 1] and [Time 2] available. Would either of those work?

If they say they're feeling better:

FRONT DESK: That's great to hear! That means the treatment is working. I do want to mention that [Therapist Name] noted you're at a really important point in your plan right now. Stopping early is actually when a lot of patients end up re-injuring or going backwards. Can we keep this appointment on the books so we make sure you're fully recovered?

If they're too busy:

FRONT DESK: I completely understand how busy things get. What if we moved you to an early morning or late afternoon slot so it's less disruptive to your day? We have [options]. That way you keep progressing without it taking over your schedule.

WHY THIS SCRIPT WORKS

A standard reminder call has zero persuasion. This script uses personalisation (therapist reviewed your chart), value reinforcement (progress is at a critical point), and alternative offers instead of acceptance. Practices that use this approach consistently see no-show reductions of 25-40%.

SCRIPT 4

How to Re-engage a Patient Who Dropped Off Their Care Plan

Use when: A patient has not been in for 3+ weeks and still has visits remaining on their plan of care.

THE GOAL

Bring them back without sounding like a collections call. Check in on their health, remind them why they started, and make it easy to rebook.

THE SCRIPT

FRONT DESK: Hi [Patient Name], this is [Your Name] from [Practice Name]. How are you doing?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Pause. Let them answer. This is a check-in, not a pitch.*

CALLER: *[Responds]*

FRONT DESK: I'm glad to hear that. I'm reaching out because I noticed it's been a little while since your last visit, and I wanted to check in and see how you're feeling. How's the [knee/back/shoulder] doing?

CALLER: *[Responds]*

If they're still hurting:

FRONT DESK: I'm sorry to hear it's still bothering you. That's actually really common when there's a gap in treatment. The good news is you still have visits available on your plan, and [Therapist Name] can pick up right where you left off. I have a couple of openings this week. Would [Day] at [Time] or [Day] at [Time] work for you?

If they're feeling better:

FRONT DESK: That's wonderful! I'm really glad the treatment helped. [Therapist Name] did want me to mention that you have a few visits left on your plan, and finishing them out can make a big difference in making sure the improvement sticks. A lot of patients who stop early end up back in the same spot a few months later. Would you like to come in for a quick follow-up? I have openings on [Day] and [Day].

If life just got in the way:

FRONT DESK: Completely understand. Life gets busy. The good news is your plan is still active and your benefits are still available, so nothing's been lost. Let's get you back on the schedule at a time that works for you. What does your week look like?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Never guilt them. Never say "you missed your appointments." Always position it as a check-in, not a reminder of what they didn't do.*

WHY THIS SCRIPT WORKS

Incomplete plans of care are one of the biggest revenue leaks in PT. A patient with 8 remaining visits at $150/visit is $1,200 in uncollected revenue. Multiply that by 10 patients per month who drop off and you are looking at $12,000+/month walking out the door. This script brings them back without pressure by leading with genuine concern for their health.

SCRIPT 5

How to Handle the 'Do You Accept My Insurance?' Call

Use when: A potential patient calls and their first question is about insurance.

THE GOAL

Go beyond yes/no. Capture their information, verify benefits, and book the appointment regardless of the coverage answer.

THE SCRIPT

CALLER: *Hi, do you accept [Insurance Name]?*

FRONT DESK: Great question! We work with most major insurance plans. Let me check on your specific plan so I can give you an accurate answer. Can I get your name and date of birth?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Do not say "no" immediately, even if you suspect you are out-of-network. Get their information first.*

CALLER: *[Provides name and DOB]*

FRONT DESK: Thank you, [Patient Name]. And do you have your insurance card available? I'll need the member ID and group number to check your benefits.

IF YOU ARE IN-NETWORK:

FRONT DESK: Great news, [Patient Name]. We are in-network with your plan. Let me pull up your specific benefits so I can let you know exactly what to expect. While I'm doing that, can you tell me a little about what's going on? What are you looking to get help with?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Transition from insurance into their health concern. Then use Script 1 to book the appointment.*

IF YOU ARE OUT-OF-NETWORK:

FRONT DESK: [Patient Name], we are considered out-of-network with your plan. But I want to make sure you know that doesn't necessarily mean you don't have coverage. A lot of plans still provide out-of-network benefits for physical therapy, which means your insurance may still cover a portion of the cost. Would you like me to check your out-of-network benefits so we can see what's available?

CALLER: *Sure, that would be great.*

FRONT DESK: I'll look into that and call you right back. In the meantime, can I ask what's going on with you? What are you hoping to get help with?

⚠️ **NOTE:** *Shift to their health concern. Even if OON benefits are limited, you can discuss self-pay rates and payment plans. The key is: do not let the call end here.*

IF THERE ARE NO OON BENEFITS:

FRONT DESK: [Patient Name], unfortunately your plan doesn't include out-of-network benefits for PT. I know that's not what you were hoping to hear. I do want you to know that we offer a very competitive self-pay rate of [$X per visit], and many of our patients find it's well worth it for the quality of care they receive. We also offer [payment plans / package pricing]. Would you like me to tell you a little more about that, or would you like to come in for an evaluation so you can meet the therapist and decide from there?

WHY THIS SCRIPT WORKS

The insurance question is not really about insurance. It is about cost certainty. Most front desks answer with a flat yes or no and the call ends. This script keeps the conversation going through every possible scenario and always ends with an attempt to book.

WANT YOUR TEAM TO ACTUALLY MASTER THESE?

Reading a script is step one. Being able to deliver it naturally, under pressure, on a real call, is step two.

That's why we created the Front Desk Efficiency Webinar, a free, one-hour session where we break down exactly where PT practices lose revenue at the front desk and how to fix it.

We also walk through the numbers so you can see what these gaps are actually costing your practice.

After the session, you can request a free Practice Analysis where we evaluate your specific practice, identify your revenue gaps, and put together a customised programme to close them.

Register for the next free session:

survivalstrategies.com/efficiency-webinar

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